Lecture 3: Foundations: Freud

Introduction to Psychology · Yale University, Spring 2007 · Professor Paul Bloom

Study guide based on the lecture transcript. Source: https://oyc.yale.edu/psychology/psyc-110/lecture-3 (CC BY-NC-SA 3.0).

Before you start

This lecture presents the ideas of Sigmund Freud, the most famous psychologist ever. Professor Bloom explains Freud's theory of the unconscious, his stages of development and his defense mechanisms. Then he asks whether Freud's theory is good science, and shows that one big idea, the importance of the unconscious, is still alive in modern psychology.

Learning goals

After this lecture you should be able to:

- Describe the id, the ego and the superego and the conflict between them.
- List Freud's five stages of psychosexual development and explain "fixation."
- Give an example of each of Freud's five defense mechanisms.
- Explain falsifiability and why critics say Freud is "not even wrong."
- Describe two modern studies that show unconscious influences on what we like and think.

Key ideas

1. Sigmund Freud in a Historical Context

- Freud's psychoanalysis and Skinner's behaviorism are "grand theories" that try to explain almost everything, from child development to mental illness, religion and love.
- Freud was born in the 1850s and spent most of his life in Vienna, Austria. He escaped to London as the Nazis came, and died there.
- He is famous for a whole theory of mind, not for one discovery. Some of his ideas, like "penis envy," are hard to take seriously.

2. Unconscious Motivation: The Id, Ego and Superego

- Freud's two key ideas are **unconscious motivation** and **unconscious conflict**, which leads to mental illness, dreams and slips of the tongue.
- Unconscious motivation means you may not know why you do what you do. For example, a Freudian might say you want to marry someone because he reminds you of your father.
- The mind has three parts in conflict:
  - The **id** is present at birth. It is the animal part and wants pleasure now (the "Pleasure Principle"). It is "outrageously stupid."
  - The **ego** (the self) works on the "Reality Principle." It plans how to satisfy desires, or how to give them up.

    - The **superego** is the internalized rules of parents and society: a conscience. It is also stupid; it just says, "You should be ashamed of yourself."
- The ego is in the middle. The forces of the id and superego are unconscious.

3. Personality Development and Psychosexual Development

- Freud believed in five stages, each linked to a part of the body. If something goes wrong at a stage, a person can get "stuck" there (fixation).
- **Oral stage:** pleasure through the mouth. Early weaning could create an "oral" person who eats too much, smokes, or is needy.
- **Anal stage:** linked to toilet training. Problems could create an "anal" personality: compulsive, clean and stingy.
- **Phallic stage:** the focus moves to the genitals. Here Freud placed the **Oedipus complex**, named after the myth of a king who killed his father and married his mother. A boy of three or four loves his mother, sees his father as a rival, fears his father's punishment, and gives up.
- **Latency stage:** sexual interest is repressed for several years. **Genital stage:** the healthy adult stage. But the inner conflict continues, and unacceptable thoughts are **repressed** (kept out of consciousness).

4. Defense Mechanisms, the Aims of Psychoanalysis, Dreams

- **Defense mechanisms** keep unacceptable thoughts out of consciousness. For Freud, they are part of normal life:
    - **Sublimation:** putting sexual or aggressive energy into something else, like Picasso putting it into art.
    - **Displacement:** moving a feeling to a safer target. A boy bullied by his father kicks the dog.
    - **Projection:** seeing your own uncomfortable desires in other people.
    - **Rationalization:** giving an acceptable reason for something bad: "It's for the child's own good."
    - **Regression:** going back to an earlier stage, like a stressed child sucking his thumb.
- When these fail, the result can be **hysteria**, for example being unable to see with nothing physically wrong.
- In psychoanalysis, the patient is hiding something from himself. Freud first used hypnosis, then **free association**. The analyst helps the patient get past **resistance** and gain **insight**.
- Dreams have **manifest content** (what you experience) and **latent content** (the hidden meaning). Freud saw all dreams as **wish fulfillment**.

5. Question and Answer on Freud's Theories

Students asked about one-parent families, women and the superego, and sublimation. Professor Bloom explained that displacement moves a feeling to another target, projection puts your own desire onto someone else, and sublimation keeps the energy but drops the details.

6. Controversies and Criticisms on Freud's Theories

- A theory can fail in two ways: it can be wrong, or it can be too vague to test. The physicist Wolfgang Pauli said of another physicist: "He's not right. He's not even wrong." Critics say this about Freud.
- The philosopher Karl Popper introduced **falsifiability**: a scientific claim must be strong enough that it *could* be proven wrong, for example "exposure to violent television tends to make children themselves more violent." A horoscope is so vague that it "can't be wrong," so astrology is not science.
- Freudians often say the theory is proven in psychoanalysis. But if the patient agrees, Freud is right; if the patient angrily disagrees, the anger "shows" Freud is right.
- When tested, Freud's specific claims do poorly. There is no evidence that oral or anal traits relate to weaning or toilet training, even across cultures. For most disorders, there are quicker and more reliable treatments than psychoanalysis.
- So Freud is rarely studied in psychology departments; at Yale, he is more likely found in history or literature.

7. Examples of the Unconscious in Modern Psychology

- Freud's big idea, the importance of the dynamic unconscious, "remains intact."
- **Language:** we instantly know that "John thinks that Bill likes him" and "John thinks that Bill likes himself" mean different things, without knowing how.
- **Skills:** expert driving can happen without awareness.
- **Likes:** people who go through a terrible initiation like the club more.
- **Subliminal death primes:** words like "corpse" are flashed too fast to see. People then become more nationalistic and less forgiving of others.
- **Norbert Schwarz:** people who list three positive features of someone they love like the person more. People who must list ten (which is hard) like the person less, and they do not know why.
- Freud is "a victim of his own success": his view is now so normal that we forget other ways of thinking.

8. Further Question and Answer on Freud

Freud believed disorders like depression and anxiety should be treated with talk therapy and insight, not medication. Dreams show some link to daily worries, but research has not supported Freud's strong claims about symbolism and wish fulfillment.

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning in simple English	Example from the lecture
unconscious	Working in the mind without our awareness	Forgetting a name at exactly the wrong time
psychoanalysis	Freud's theory and his talk therapy	Free association to find hidden problems
id	The part of the mind that wants pleasure now	Wants to eat, drink and get warm

Term	Meaning in simple English	Example from the lecture
ego	The self; deals with reality	Sits between the id and the superego
superego	Rules of parents and society inside us; conscience	"You should be ashamed of yourself"
fixation	Getting "stuck" at a stage of development	An "oral" or "anal" personality
defense mechanism	A way to keep shameful thoughts out of awareness	Displacement: kicking the dog
latent content	The hidden meaning of a dream	Freud: every dream hides a wish
falsifiability	Being able to be proven wrong	A clear prediction, unlike a vague horoscope
subliminal	Below the level of consciousness	Death words flashed too fast to see

Check your understanding

1. What are the id, the ego and the superego? Which principle does the id work on?
2. According to Freud, what happens if something goes wrong at one stage of development? Give an example.
3. A worker is angry at his boss but shouts at his younger brother instead. Which defense mechanism is this?
4. What is the difference between the manifest and the latent content of a dream?
5. What is falsifiability, and why is a horoscope not falsifiable?
6. Freudians say "The Freudian theory proves itself in the course of psychoanalysis." Why is this weak evidence?
7. Describe Norbert Schwarz's study. What does it show?
8. Why is Freud "a victim of his own success"?

Answer guide

1. The id wants pleasure now; the ego deals with reality; the superego is the conscience. The id works on the Pleasure Principle.
2. The person can become fixated, or stuck. For example, early weaning could make an "oral" person who is needy.
3. Displacement: moving a feeling from a forbidden target to a safer one.
4. Manifest content is what you experience in the dream. Latent content is its hidden meaning.
5. A falsifiable claim could be proven wrong by evidence. A horoscope is so vague that nothing could show it is wrong.
6. Any answer counts as support. If the patient agrees, Freud is right; if the patient disagrees, the anger "shows" he is right.
7. People listed three or ten positive features of someone they love. Listing ten is hard, so they liked the person less, without knowing why. It shows unconscious influences on liking.
8. His general idea changed our world view so much that it is hard to remember any other way of thinking. So we underestimate his importance.

English practice

Useful phrases from the lecture

- "One way to describe this... is..." - introduces a simpler explanation. Example: "One way to describe this in a non-technical, non-Freudian way is..."
- "...to some extent..." - means "partly." Example: "to some extent, this accusation has some truth to it."
- "He's not right. He's not even wrong." - criticizes a claim that is too vague to test.
- "The point of this illustration, again, is that..." - explains why an example was given.

Speaking task (with your AI tutor)

- Explain the conflict inside the mind according to Freud in 4-6 sentences. Use these terms: *id*, *superego*, *unconscious*.
- Explain why many scientists criticize Freud in 4-6 sentences. Use these terms: *falsifiability*, *vague*, *evidence*.

Writing task

- Write one paragraph (80-120 words): Why are most of Freud's particular theories rejected, while his idea of the unconscious is still important? Use one criticism and one modern study from the lecture.

Study with your tutor

Things to say to your tutor in Live conversation:

- "Let's review Lecture 3. Ask me questions about the id, ego and superego, one at a time."
- "Quiz me on the key vocabulary of Lecture 3."
- "Give me short situations. I will name the defense mechanism in each one."
- "I will explain falsifiability in my own words. Check my understanding and my English."

Readings from the original course

- Gray, Peter. Psychology (5th edition), pp. 558-563, 632-637
- Freud, Sigmund. "The Unconscious." In The Norton Psychology Reader. Edited by Gary Marcus. New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2006. pp. 12-17

My notes